INDIA TODAY CONCLAVE 2025 SOUTH


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Can Bengaluru's new infrastructure roadmap transform the southern metropolis? Can Amaravati be the template to building new cities from the ground-up? How is the political battleground shaping up in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, which go to assembly polls in 2026? What keeps southern cinema ticking? As the sixth edition of the 'India Today Conclave–South' kicked off in Coimbatore this month, a rich variety of discussions foregrounded the vibrant sweep of the peninsula, from its politics to industry to culture.

The keynote sessions and panel discussions, headlined by Karnataka deputy chief minister D.K. Shivakumar and Nara Lokesh, HRD minister of Andhra Pradesh, featured as many as five ministers from the southern states. Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin spoke via videoconference. "Federalism should become stronger," he said. "State rights should be protected. We continue to fight for it." Outlining his vision for Bengaluru, Shivakumar said the Karnataka government has earmarked investments of over Rs 1 lakh crore for the tech capital over the next 3-4 years.

Day One of the conclave began with two former chief election commissioners and a former election commissioner weighing in on the hot topics of the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls and delimitation. "What truly matters," as former election commissioner Ashok Lavasa put it, "is the sanctity and integrity of the electoral rolls."

Next up was Nara Lokesh declaring that Andhra Pradesh CM and his father N. Chandrababu Naidu's agenda was firmly on making his state No. 1, and that his Telugu Desam Party (TDP) stood steadfast behind the NDA government led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "TDP has joined the NDA unconditionally, it continues to support NDA unconditionally," he said.

While conversations on caste census, education policy and cooperative federalism drew insightful perspectives from an eclectic range of speakers, the conclave also featured absorbing discussions on healthcare, delivery of digital services and the dynamics of the southern real estate boom. Actors Rukmini Vasanth and Shwetha Menon were the highlight of the sessions on films and entertainment, while GenZ was represented by two promising youngsters: Andhra-born Jahnavi Dangeti who is training to be an astronaut, and Artificial Intelligence enthusiast Raul John Aju from Kerala. The show-stopper, fittingly for the high-octane event, was Coimbatore's own Narain Karthikeyan, the posterboy of Indian racing. ■

–by Ajay Sukumaran

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